NEXIUS LABS // FIELD GUIDE

The SME AI Workflow

Opportunity Checklist

A 10-minute diagnostic to find the one workflow in your business

that AI should automate first — and the three that shouldn't.

> ***Orchestrate, don't operate.***
>
> Most SMEs don't fail at AI because the tools aren't ready. They fail because they automate the wrong workflow first. This checklist fixes that.

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01 Before you start

Every SME owner we speak to is under the same pressure: do more with the team you already have. AI is the obvious lever. The problem is that the first workflow you automate often decides whether the whole initiative works or quietly dies.

This checklist is built from the patterns we see repeatedly inside SMEs — operations, service, sales, finance, HR. It is designed to take about ten minutes and help you separate workflows that are genuinely ready for AI from the ones that need cleaning up first.

Who this is for

Owners, operators, and department heads in businesses between roughly 10 and 250 staff. You don't need to be technical. If you can describe how work gets done today, you can use this checklist.

How to use it

1. **Pick** one workflow you think is a candidate. Not the whole department. One workflow.
2. **Work through each of the 15 statements** across the three sections below. Tick the box only when the statement is clearly true today.
3. **Count your ticks and use the scoring guide** to decide your next move.
4. **Repeat for 2–3 candidate workflows.** Automate the highest-scoring one first.

> **A QUICK NOTE ON HONESTY**
> Be strict with yourself. If you're unsure whether a statement is true, treat it as a no. The goal isn't to qualify as many workflows as possible — it's to find the one that will actually succeed.

02 Workflow suitability

Is the workflow itself shaped in a way AI can actually help with? Five questions.

- ☐ **This workflow happens at least weekly.**
  AI pays off through repetition. A workflow that runs twice a year rarely justifies the setup cost — weekly or daily is the sweet spot.
- ☐ **The workflow follows a repeatable sequence of steps.**
  If two people would complete it in broadly the same way, it's repeatable enough. If every case is completely unique, it's not a good first candidate.
- ☐ **The team already uses templates, SOPs, or standard response patterns.**
  Existing templates are gold. They are the patterns an AI system can learn from and scale — not replace.
- ☐ **The workflow uses information from documents, emails, spreadsheets, or forms.**
  Structured or semi-structured inputs are where modern AI performs best. If the inputs live only in someone's head, capture them first.
- ☐ **The output can be clearly described — a report, summary, reply, draft, update, or decision recommendation.**
  If you can't describe what "good" looks like in one sentence, the AI won't be able to produce it either.

03 Business value

Would automating this workflow actually move the needle? Five questions.

- ☐ **The workflow consumes enough time that faster execution would matter.**
  Rough rule: if the team spends under an hour a week on it, look elsewhere. Prioritise workflows that quietly eat days, not minutes.
- ☐ **Delays in this workflow affect customers, managers, or other teams.**
  The strongest AI wins aren't about doing the same thing cheaper — they're about doing it fast enough to change what's possible downstream.
- ☐ **Errors or inconsistency in this workflow create rework or risk.**
  Compliance slips, pricing mistakes, duplicated data entry — these are where AI with proper guardrails earns its keep.
- ☐ **Improving this workflow would free skilled staff for higher-value work.**
  The point isn't headcount reduction. It's moving your best people off admin and onto the work only they can do.
- ☐ **Success can be measured — time saved, turnaround, quality, capacity, or revenue.**
  If you can't agree on a number before you start, you won't agree on whether the pilot worked afterwards.

04 Readiness and controls

Can your business safely let AI into this workflow today? Five questions.

- ☐ **A human can review or approve the final output when needed.**
  Human-in-the-loop isn't a fallback — it's the design. The right question is where the approval point sits, not whether it exists.
- ☐ **The workflow can be broken into steps that AI can assist with safely.**
  You rarely automate a whole workflow end-to-end on day one. You automate the safe, high-volume steps and keep humans on the rest.
- ☐ **The data involved can be shared with approved tools under company policy.**
  Customer PII, financials, and regulated data all have rules. Know them before you pick the workflow, not after.
- ☐ **There is a clear process owner who can define rules, edge cases, and escalation points.**
  No owner, no project. AI systems need someone who will say "this is how we handle that exception" with authority.
- ☐ **The team is willing to run a 2–4 week pilot and measure honestly.**
  Culture eats automation for breakfast. A team that wants it to work will iterate through the rough first version; a team that doesn't won't.

05 Score your workflow

Count the boxes you ticked across all three sections. Your total is out of 15. Find your band below.

Score	Verdict	What to do next
12–15	**Green light**	Move to pilot design this week. Pick an owner, define one success metric, and run a 2–4 week pilot.
8–11	**Promising**	Fix the weak points first. Close the gaps revealed by the unticked statements, then re-score before piloting.
0–7	**Not yet**	Improve the process manually. Automating a broken workflow just gets you broken output, faster.

> **THE MOST USEFUL QUESTION**
>
> If your score is 8–11, don't ask "should we automate this?" Ask "which specific boxes did we miss, and who owns closing them by next Friday?" That's the question that moves a workflow from promising to green light.

06 Worked example

A services firm scoring customer onboarding

A 40-person professional services firm runs this checklist against their client onboarding workflow — the sequence that kicks off after a contract is signed. Here is what the scoring looked like.

Section	Score	Notes
A. Suitability	**5 / 5**	Onboarding runs every week, follows a checklist, and produces clear outputs (welcome email, kickoff deck, project folder).
B. Value	**5 / 5**	Currently takes 6–8 hours per client across three people. Delays push back the first billable day.
C. Readiness	**3 / 5**	No single owner, and part of the data sits in a shared inbox with no policy on AI tool access.
Total	**13 / 15**	**Green light — pilot-ready after assigning an owner and sorting inbox access.**

What they did next

1. Named the operations manager as workflow owner.
2. Documented four exception types from the last 20 clients.
3. Piloted an AI workflow that drafts the welcome email, sets up the project folder, and produces the kickoff deck — with the ops manager approving before send.
4. Result after three weeks: onboarding time dropped from ~7 hours to ~45 minutes of review. First billable day moved forward by three days on average.

07 Your next 7 days

Once you've scored at least one workflow, the work becomes concrete. Use this as your week-one plan.

1. Name one workflow owner. This person decides rules and edge cases.
2. Map inputs, outputs, approvals, and exceptions on one page. No more.
3. Pick one narrow pilot use case — not the whole workflow, just the highest-volume slice.
4. Agree one success metric with a number attached: hours saved, turnaround days, error rate.
5. Run the pilot for 2–4 weeks. Review honestly. Expand, adjust, or kill.

READY TO GO DEEPER?

Build the workflow with us, not alone.

Nexius Labs designs and ships AI agent systems for SMEs. We orchestrate the workflow end-to-end — pilot, measure, and scale — so your team stays focused on the work only they can do.

→ Book a 30-minute workflow review at **nexiuslabs.com**

→ Or train your team yourself at **Nexius Academy** — SkillsFuture-eligible AI training for practical business workflows.